Epilogue

> “But if nothing we do here has any guarantee of lasting, if even the best gestures have only a slim chance of outliving us, is there any reason not to just give up?”
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> “Every reason in the world,” Rudd said. “We’re here, and we’re alive. It’s a beautiful evening, on the last perfect day of summer.”
>
> Alastair Reynolds, *Pushing Ice*

Martin Rees isn’t building any cathedrals.

We are sitting in his office at Cambridge University’s Institute of Astronomy on a sunny June morning, and he is telling me that humanity as we know it will be forgotten. “In the Middle Ages, the cathedral builders were happy to build a cathedral that would be there for more than their lifetime, because they thought that their grandchildren would appreciate it and would live lives like them. Whereas I don’t think we have that.” Rees is no stranger to far-future speculation, having written books about the future of humanity and all the different ways we might accidentally doom ourselves. According to him, evolution, in the cultural and technological sense, is accelerating so fast that whatever the dominant intelligence is in the next few hundred or thousand years, we can’t predict what it will be like. But we can be sure that it won’t care about us. “I think to leave a legacy for a hundred years is a bolder ambition now than it would have been for our ancestors,” he says.

“Does that upset you?” I ask him.

“It upsets me very much. But why should the world be made the way we like it?”

It’s impossible to seriously contemplate the end of the universe without ultimately coming to terms with what it means for humanity. Even if you take the position that Rees’s view is overly pessimistic, there has to come a point in any timeline with a finite extent where our legacy as a species just … stops. Whatever legacy-based rationalization we use to make peace with our own personal deaths (perhaps we leave behind children, or great works, or somehow make the world a better place), none of that can survive the